



“THERE’S A CASE FOR UNITING AND KEEPING APPS SEPARATE”

UDAY SHANKAR, VICE CHAIRPERSON OF RELIANCE-DISNEY MEDIA JV, ON THE ENTITY’S PLANS, THE FUTURE OF APPOINTMENT VIEWING, SUBSCRIPTIONS, AND MORE

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THE RELIANCE-DISNEY media joint venture has massive scale, size and reach. But what are its implications and what is the way ahead? In an interaction with *Business Today*, Uday Shankar, 62, Vice Chairperson of the entity and Co-founder of venture capital firm Bodhi Tree Systems, talks about linear television, OTT, cricket rights, and the long-term vision. Edited excerpts:



The Reliance-Disney media joint venture is a behemoth. What does this mean for viewers?

Mergers and combinations do not change viewers’ lives, but the outcome does. We are very determined to use this merger as an opportunity to completely

reinvent the content and its experience ecosystem. India has been a great content market, and the history of television and video is less than 30 years old. It has emerged as one of the most exciting video markets on linear television, the internet and everywhere else. The time is ripe to enhance that experience and take it to the next level across platforms. We are ideally positioned to do that because of our volume of content across genres.

Between Colors and Star, we have more capabilities and content across drama and reality than anyone else. On internet and streaming we have Hotstar and JioCinema. Hotstar created streaming in India

and JioCinema made a significant intervention there. This is a great opportunity to change the viewing ecosystem.



Are you looking to combine your streaming platforms?

There is a case for bringing the two together as is keeping them apart. Hotstar has emerged as a very well-rounded entertainment destination for Hollywood and Indian content. JioCinema has had a much shorter lifespan and started with live sports and prominently cricket. Both have their core identities, and we are now examining options.



The combined entity,

with both linear TV and OTT, can command a price from advertisers. How do you view that?

We do have scale and reach—750 million viewers come to these platforms collectively every week. We also have great brand affinity between Star, Colors, JioCinema, and Hotstar. Then, there is content from India and the rest of the world. That said, monetisation depends on the capacity of the market.

While we incur costs and are committed to delivering content, which is in our control, getting money for that is not. We all know advertising on television has been under pressure. On streaming, advertising has been growing very healthily, but the size of the market